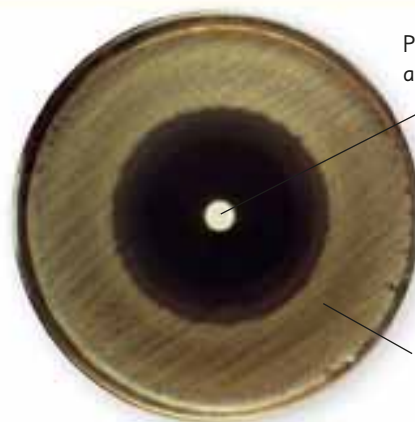




Sir Alexander Fleming (1881–1955)

Penicillin

In 1928, Sir Alexander Fleming made an important discovery. He realised that the mould *Penicillium notatum* makes a chemical that kills bacteria. That chemical, called penicillin, is used today as a medicine to treat many illnesses.



Penicillin on a petri dish

The bacteria have retreated from the penicillin, leaving a clear ring.

Truffles

Truffles are strong-smelling fungi that grow underground. They are a delicacy used in cookery. Truffle hunters use pigs and dogs to sniff them out.

White truffle



Black perigord truffle



Shaggy parasol mushroom

Shaggy cap mushroom

Common chantarelle mushroom

Chicken of the woods fungus

Yeast

Yeast are microscopic, single-celled fungi. When they feed, they turn sugar into carbon-dioxide gas and alcohol. Yeast plays an important part in bread-making. As it releases gas, it makes bread rise.



Uses of fungi

Fungi have many uses in the home and in industry.



Medicine: Fungi can be used to cure many diseases that were once fatal.



Wine: Yeast turns grape juice into wine by changing sugar into alcohol.



Cheese: Blue cheeses are made with a mould called *Penicillium roquefortii*.



Soy sauce: This is made by adding fungi and yeast to soy beans and roasted wheat.



Pesticide: Fungi can be an environmentally friendly way of killing insects or weeds.

